



Mr. Sabu Jacob (Executive Director)

KITEX GARMENTS - VISION & CULTURE

It's easy to believe. From the moment you meet him, Sabu Jacob, the Indian born Chair of KiteX Garments, comes across as warm-hearted, generous and sincere. In the fabrics game, he reveals, there's simply no other way to do business.

A man with vision and extraordinary vision brings The KiteX A unique brand and culture and he succeeded providing quality products and design. He has been Managing Director of KiteX Garments Ltd. since August 16, 2006 and has been its Chief Financial Officer since January 25, 2016. Mr. Jacob serves as the Chairman of KiteX Garments Ltd. He has 25 years experience and previously served as an Executive Director of KiteX Ltd. He holds B.A. Economics degree. He belongs to a family of entrepreneurs who have promoted many industrial units for producing textiles, garment, vessels, spices, umbrellas, school bags etc.

Established in 1992 KiteX Garments Ltd is into 100% exports of cotton garments especially infant wear. The company exports its products to US and European markets. The vertically integrated manufacturing plant makes infant wear as well as fabrics. He shared the incredible insights with The Executives Magazine Fashion is my passion. It's an industry that's always changing. The fabrications, designs and styles that I am doing this year are completely different to the ones I did last year. We have to work for the future, and that's very interesting for me. It's challenging."

"Our customers and suppliers, we all know them personally," he shares. "We know their families; we're very close to them. And they know us. We look after each other. It's a very close-knit industry. Even though there are thousands and thousands of players." when it comes to employees We give them perks like free doctors and a good

salary. They're very happy with us, and we are also very happy with them. I believe that taking care of our staff only makes us stronger." In return, employees work hard to look after the business.

"Because we have a good management system and a well-established supply chain managed by highly skilled professionals, we are able to reduce delivery times for our clients,"

My efficiency is much higher than anybody else in any part of the world. For example, the world average maximum efficiency in this industry is not more than 50 or 55 per cent – my efficiency is 75 per cent on average.

"People think invest less, make more money. My psychology is different – invest more and get more efficiency and hence make more money."

It's a philosophy that appears to have borne fruit for KiteX, which was founded in 1995. Sabu still recalls the challenges of starting out and struggling to get customers to visit the factory, prompting him to reassess and redirect the business into the babywear market.

As well as the investment in infrastructure, including air conditioning throughout the factory, Sabu stresses that KiteX has put a great deal of money into technology, chemistry and the welfare of its workers – a matter that has recently come under scrutiny.

"When you create an air-conditioned, comfortable ambience much like a university campus, your workers are mentally and physically much better – they're much stronger and they're not tired," he says. "Then, I'm giving them four meals every day, non-vegetarian,



unlimited food free of charge. It's not mandatory to give them food, but I'm giving food four times a day, every day, and 100 per cent free."

Kitex also provides workers with dormitory-style accommodation, although Sabu insists there is no obligation for them to stay there and that there are alternatives available. It is also now offering medical cover to its workers, he adds.

"In my factory, every worker is in a permanent role," he continues. "There are no temporary workers or contract labour. Everyone in our factory, from day one, is eligible for all these benefits, like ESI medical insurance, provident fund, gratuities, bonuses and holidays."

But rather than hiking up Kitex's costs, these measures help the company to remain competitive, according to Sabu, who says the company's clients are pleasantly surprised when they receive their quotes. "I am giving the same price

that they would get in China, Cambodia or Vietnam. That's my success," he says.

Although the US currently accounts for 100 per cent of Kitex's business, the expansion will see Sabu target the European and Australian markets as well. Catering to these highly regulated markets means that the company must adhere to the highest possible standards.

Its focus on babywear also brings with it certain stipulations, particularly with regards to safety. "It can lead into huge damages and compensation so we decided to invest on the process side to ensure the safety of our products," he shares. "Now, we import all the chemicals and dyes from Europe – nothing is from India, except the water."

Dyes are extensively tested and certified by OEKO-TEX according to its general standards for clothing, as well as more stringent standards for infants.

In addition, all of its dyes and chemicals are certified by the Global Organic Textile Standard (GOTS). "We are the only factory with organic processing and 100 per cent of our products are GOTS-certified," Sabu says.

"Kitex is totally different from any other manufacturer, not only in India but in any part of the world. Our infrastructure is different – no one else has such an investment in their infrastructure. They tend to think less investment, more profit. But my views are different."

While the company's existing factory was imported from Saudi Arabia, this new factory will be imported from Dubai. "We are actually not keeping to Indian standards, we're going to keep international standards – on par with what America and Europe are doing," Sabu says. "That's the difference of this factory."

Between them, the two new factories will produce 2.4 million pieces per day

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in capacity by 2025. Combined with the existing facility, built in 1995 and expanded in 2012, that will take Kitex's daily output to a staggering 3.2 million pieces per day.

"It took almost 17 years to reach production of 800,000 pieces," Sabu reflects. "Now, within four years, I am going to increase my capacity to three times that of today."

Kitex currently employs 11,000 people in its factory but by using cutting-edge technology and expertise, only 22,000 people will be required to generate the additional 2.4 million pieces. "The productivity is very high there," he emphasises. "It should be 33,000 people but I'm taking only 22,000 and making a huge saving."

At present, the company produces only 100 per cent cotton garments for infants but this new expansion phase will see it add two more items to its portfolio.

The first is children's socks, which Kitex's clients currently buy from countries such as China and Thailand. The other is fleece clothing, high in demand in Kitex's number one market of the US as well as Europe. At present, such items are bought from China, Cambodia and Vietnam.

Managing Director of Kitex Garments – the second largest infant garment maker globally – has sewn up detailed

plans for his ₹3,000-crore investment in the State.

Two swank facilities, one in the Kakatiya Mega Textile Park at Warangal, and the other at Sitarampur near Hyderabad, are speedily getting ready to roll out a combined 2.4 million pieces per day, adding to the existing 8 lakh pieces per day capacity in Kerala, says Jacob.



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